FODMAP Label Reading Tutorial

High FODMAP ingredients are often added to food products.

It's important to be able to identify them in the ingredients section of the food label. Here is an example of a low FODMAP snack vs high FODMAP that I did in a previous online workshop.

FODMAP Label Reading Guide

Here is a label reading guide that you can use to identify high FODMAP and low FODMAP ingredients.

The green boxes are low FODMAP ingredients and safe to eat. The red and orange are high FODMAP and should be avoided during the elimination phase.

Emulsifiers and Gums

There is some confusion surrounding carrageenan, xanthan gum an guar gum, which are common food additives.

These are all low FODMAP and permitted on a low FODMAP diet in moderate quantities.

However, some do not absorb the gums well and they can cause digestive stress in select people (but it's unrelated to FODMAPs specifically).

So they are permitted, but keep that in mind if you are having symptoms despite a strict low FODMAP diet.

Additional Tips

Knowing what to look for on food labels is incredibly important- even more so on the low FODMAP diet.

At the bottom of this lesson is a list you can download of the main high FODMAP ingredients you need to be aware of.

The video below is a great 1-minute primer from Buzzfeed on how to read labels in general. I strongly recommend you watch this quickly, even if you think you already know how.

Video Transcripts

Okay, moving on is step number five, get familiar with basic label reading. Now, not reading labels and continuing to eat foods with high FODMAP ingredients is bad. FODMAP's can hide in sneaky places and small amounts, when eaten regularly, can prevent symptom relief. So, I want to give you a couple of practical tips here, now and also an example.

So tip number one. Know which foods do not contain FODMAP's. I want to reiterate what I said before about the free foods. So fresh meat, chicken, fish, eggs, they all don't contain any FODMAP's. So remember that. Butter, margarine, fats, and oils also don't contain hardly any carbs, if at all. Therefore, they don't contain any FODMAP's. Note though, with the meat, for example, chicken, any flavors or mayonnaise because they may very well have FODMAPs'.

For example, chicken is often marinated with something that contains garlic. So therefore, the chicken would now be high FODMAP because of its marinade, not because of the chicken. Tip number two. Forget about the front of the books and turn over to the ingredients list. Ingredients are listed in descending order from largest to smallest. So ingredients to look out for, in particular, are inulin, chicory, vegetable fiber, fruit juice, fruit fiber, fructo-oligosaccharides, high fructose corn syrup, osomalt, xylito, sorbitol, mannitol, erythritol, garlic and onion powder, honey, and agave syrup, to name a few.

Tip number three. Shop the perimeter. So a whole unprocessed foods that don't have an ingredients list or with the shorter ingredients list are often easier to navigate when you're first starting out with a diet. For example, the ingredients in plain rice or quinoa reads "ingredients rice" or "ingredients quinoa." Super simple to determine if it's [inaudible 00:02:04] high FODMAP. An example here. So we have two different types of Doritos. One is plain corn Doritos and the other one is Nacho Cheese.

So if we go to the left first, you can see the ingredients here below the picture. Ingredients corn, vegetable oil, and in the vegetable oil there is [inaudible 00:02:29] corn canola, and [inaudible 00:02:31] oil, and salt. So there's no high FODMAP ingredients here. Corn chips are in fact low FODMAP to about 50 grams or one very small packet. On the right though, we have a product that is even more highly processed and therefore has a lot of ingredients. So what I'm saying is it's very likely that products like this are gonna have some high FODMAP ingredients in their and if you eat them, you're gonna exceed your threshold and you're gonna get symptoms.

So if we just go through, I'm not gonna read them all, but you can see what I've underlined in red. So you've got like wheat flour, in the cheddar cheese is milk, that's got lactose in it, that's a FODMAP, buttermilk, part-skim cows milk, white protein concentrate, that contains lactose, onion powder, definitely high FODMAP. Even here it lists lactose. That's a FODMAP itself. Spices, spices usually contain onion or garlic or both. Garlic powder, skim milk, high FODMAP. So you can see going for the more simple foods in the beginning when you're learning about all this.